

helping HANDS

* The Banyan

Project Caring for mentally ill and destitute women

Can-do Icon
Chellamma, the first patient to be rescued

11 lakh

is the total number of mentally ill destitute in India



Walking away from the underprivileged on the street is second nature. Accepting and caring for them without inhibition remains uncommon. But that is precisely what Vandhana Gopikumar and Vaishnavi Jayakumar, who started the Banyan in 1993, an NGO for mentally ill, destitute women have set out to do. They have reached out to more than

1,800 women and rehabilitated and reunited them with their families. The Banyan runs two projects, Adaikalam in Mogappair, currently housing 230 women, and the Community Mental Health Programme at Kovalam, Chennai, with 52 women.

The founders are as enthusiastic about their endeavour as they were 15 years ago, when they helped a half-naked woman lying outside their college and put her in a shelter. Starting an organisation wasn't easy, right from convincing their parents to organising funds. Their first patient was Chellamma, who was picked up from a temple in Chetpet Dobikana. "I had a TVS Champ, which Vaishnavi and I used to look for abandoned women. That is how we found Chellamma,"

says Gopikumar who did her post-graduation in medical and psychiatric social work. When they reunited Chellamma with her family in Ramanathapuram, they experienced their first success.

The Banyan has now become a 200-member strong organisation, with psychiatrists, general physicians and volunteers. "The women who come to us are physically and mentally abused and their self-esteem is rock-bottom," says Jayakumar who was a student of English literature. They follow a step-by-step procedure to restore order in their lives. After being fed and medically treated, they are taught skills to earn a living. Simultaneously, efforts to trace their family continue and once reunited, life-long follow-ups and a free supply of medicine is provided with frequent psychiatric evaluation.

"We spend Rs 1 lakh per day on food, clothes and basic amenities for the two projects," says Jayakumar. The NGO runs wholly on donations by industries, service clubs and individuals like Nachiket Mor, Deputy Director, ICICI Bank, the Ratan Tata Trust, Philips India, Reliance Fresh, Sundaram trust and Zurich Financial Services, the UK. It also gets support from the Ministry of Human Resource Development's Swadhar Scheme.

The Banyan has also teamed up with the police by introducing the Dial-100 mental helpline, started a vocational training and employment centre as well as an outlet for community health care for rural and urban outreach. "We have also partnered with four organisations to support our mission," says Gopikumar, who is married to Senthilkumar, director of Real Image Media Technologies in Chennai.

With the motto that nothing is impossible, they have stuck to their belief of individualisation, not institutionalisation.

by Lakshmi Subramanian



CHANGING LIVES: Gopikumar (extreme right) and Jayakumar with mentally ill women

Important things have been accomplished by people who kept trying when there was no hope.

VANDHANA GOPIKUMAR, Co-founder, The Banyan